WMD proliferation, drug trafficking, fundamentalism and Naxalism … Thus, today the stability of our region is as critical for our progress as is the peace and tranquillity within our geographical confines.

Even as the possibility of conventional warfare is gradually receding, the application of irregular warfare or a 'proxy war' by inimical forces in the form of both state and non-state actors remains a serious threat. Thus, the seeds of discord are being sown through war by other means, by using terrorism and insurgency as a weapon of proxy, to keep forces of disintegration and discord alive and simmering. Naxalism today has emerged as the single biggest internal security threat to the country. These emergent challenges have ushered in the need for a new genre of fighting men; soldiers who are sensitive to these new nuances … soldiers who are required to be aware of economic realities, social transformation, technological advances and are adept at keeping pace with the ever-changing panorama of high-technology and information warfare.

While facing the challenge of terrorism, insurgency or Naxalism, I have advocated the concept of an 'iron fist and velvet glove'. The iron fist is for the terrorists, the hardcore militants or Naxals and the velvet glove is for the people, the citizens of our country, and 99 per cent of them are innocent. We have to win their hearts and minds if we want to win this war.

The demands on soldiers include a deeper insight into conventional, sub-conventional and non-conventional aspects of warfare and not merely proficiency in the traditional form of war fighting as your predecessors had learnt and implemented. Also, today, no one is insulated from the lenses of media, which is real-time, so transparency and application of professional conduct becomes critical. The organizational 'naam and izzat' is our beholden duty.

I am very impressed by a quote of Field Marshal Slim, who led our forces in Burma turning defeat into victory and the man who made this statement: 'The real test of leadership is not if your men will follow you in success, but if they stick by you in defeat and hardship.'